

Overview of B2 First for Schools Writing Paper

Aims of the lesson	To introduce students to the requirements of the B2 First for Schools Writing Paper (Paper 2).
Time needed	30 minutes
Materials required	- Classroom worksheet 1 (one per student) - Classroom worksheet 2 (copied and cut up) http://www.cambridgeenglish.org/exams-and-qualifications/first-for-schools/exam-update-for-2015/

Procedure

- Before this activity, make enough copies of **Classroom worksheet 2** for students to be able to read the information easily. Cut the copies into 3 boxes. Stick or pin the boxes on the classroom walls.
- Divide the class into two groups, and divide the board into two halves. Ask for one volunteer from each group to come up to write on the board. Ask group 1 to call out the different things they have to write for their school work, in their own language or in English (for example, essays, reports on experiments, etc). Ask group 2 to call out the different things they write at home or for activities out of school, in their own language or in English (for example, emails, notes, etc). As they call out their ideas, the students at the board should write them down. Allow about 2 minutes for this.

Timing: 5 mins

- Go through some of the ideas that students have given and elicit which ones they enjoy most. Establish as well some of the different people they write to. If possible, highlight a range of different text types and registers.

Timing: 5 mins

- Elicit what kind of texts students think they may have to write in the B2 First for Schools Writing paper, Paper 2.

Timing: 3 mins

- Tell the students that they are going to read some information about the Writing Paper of B2 First for Schools, Paper 2. This information is in three parts, on the walls of the classroom.

- Put students into groups of 3. Give out **Classroom worksheet 1**. Explain that students must use the information in the paragraphs on the walls to fill in the missing information in the table. Label each student in the groups A, B or C. One of the students (e.g. A) gets up and finds the relevant text (i.e. A). Only they can read this text, and they cannot take the text off the wall or call out answers across the classroom. They should find the relevant missing information, go back to their group and tell one of the other students what to write in the table. (Students can be either a reader or a writer at any one time: they cannot read a text, sit down and write the information themselves.) Repeat with the other texts (the texts can be read in any order).

Timing: 5 mins

7. When the first group finishes, they should call out 'Stop!' Check answers with the whole class (see **Answers to Classroom worksheet 1**).

Timing: 3 mins

8. Board the questions below and in pairs or groups the students discuss their ideas. Afterwards feed back and discuss students' reactions to what they have found out about the Writing paper:
- Which part of the Writing Paper will you find easier: Part 1 or Part 2?
 - Which kinds of text will you find easy/difficult to write?
 - What do you think will be most difficult about the Writing Paper?
 - How can you improve your writing in English? (Point out that writing skill can benefit from both reading and writing as much as possible in English. Contributing to a forum or a social networking websites in English can help as much as writing essays for the teacher.)

Timing: 5 mins

Additional information

Set text question (Part 2, question 5)

- This is based on a book, but students can also answer this question if they have seen the film but not read the book.
- Although it is not obligatory for students to study the book or watch the film in class, it is important for them to know that they are expected to base their answer on the actual book or film. If they attempt the question with no knowledge of the book or the film, they may write answers which are not relevant, and therefore lose marks.

Assessment

Examiners mark tasks using Assessment Scales that were developed with explicit reference to the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages (CEFR). The scales, which are used across the spectrum of Cambridge ESOL's General and Business English Writing tests, consist of four sub-scales: Content, Communicative Achievement, Organisation, and Language:

Content focuses on how well the candidate has fulfilled the task, in other words if they have done what they were asked to do.

Communicative Achievement focuses on how appropriate the writing is for the task and whether the candidate has used the appropriate register.

Organisation focuses on the way the candidate puts together the piece of writing, in other words if it is logical, ordered and cohesive.

Language focuses on vocabulary and grammar. This includes the range of language as well as how accurate it is.

Responses are marked on each sub-scale from 0 to 5. Further details of the Assessment Scales can be found in the Handbook.

Classroom worksheet 1

	Part 1	Part 2
1. How many questions do you have to answer?	One	
2. How many questions can you choose from?	One – this is the _____ task	_____ – question 5 is the _____ question
3. What type of text should you write?	_____	Article, _____ letter , review or story (Questions 2 - 4), Article, essay, letter or review (Question _____)
4. How many words should you write?	140 – _____ words	140 – _____ words
5. Is there any extra information, apart from the question, to help you write your answer?	_____ – You will be given some information (usually prompts/bullet points). You must address the prompts in your answer and introduce an idea of your own.	_____ – You are told what to write (article / story / review, etc.) and given a topic to write about and a _____ to answer.

Answers to Classroom worksheet 1

	Part 1	Part 2
1. How many questions do you have to answer?	One	One
2. How many questions can you choose from?	One – this is the compulsory task	Four – Question 5 is the set text question
3. What type of text should you write?	Essay	Article, email/letter , review or story (Questions 2 - 4), Article, essay, letter or review (Question 5)
4. How many words should you write?	140– 190 words	140– 190 words
5. Is there any extra information, apart from the question, to help you write your answer?	Yes – You will be given some information (usually prompts/bullet points). You must address the prompts in your answer and introduce an idea of your own.	Yes – You are told what to write (article/story/review, etc.) and given a topic to write about and a question to answer.

Classroom worksheet 2

A

In the Writing Paper (Paper 2), you have to write two pieces of work. In Part 1, there is a task you have to do – an essay – this is compulsory. In Part 2 you answer one question from a choice of four (Questions 2 – 5).

B

In Part 1, you should write between 140 and 190 words. In Part 2, you should write between 140 and 190 words.
For Part 1, you are given an essay question and some prompts. You must address the prompts in your essay and include an idea of your own.

C

For Questions 2 – 4, you have to write an article, email/letter, review or story. If you have studied one of the set texts in class for Question 5, then you can choose to answer this question. You may have to write an essay, letter, article or review about the book.